

McMaster Research Ethics Board (MREB)

Jun/08/2026

Principal Investigator: Dr. Spencer Smith

Supervisor:

Student Principal Investigator: Mr Ziyang Fang

Applicant: Spencer Smith

Project Title: State of the Practice for Scientific Software

MREB#: 8215

Dear Researcher(s),

I have had the opportunity to review your application and supporting documents, as well as the feedback I received from any assigned delegated reviewer(s). A few concerns were identified; these are summarized below. Please respond to these items at your earliest convenience by following the instructions below.

Steps to Respond to MREB Ethics Review Comments:

1) Go to question 1.4 in the online application and select “Response to ethics review comments from the MREB Chair”;

2) Revise the Online Form in MacREM;

- Refer to reviewer comments below.
- Navigate to applicable questions within the online form and make the revisions.
- Edits to text fields in the main form should be made within the online interface so the system can track the changes (as opposed to making changes in a Word document and then pasting back into MacREM).

3) Revise Supporting Documents if Required (e.g. Letter of Information, Questionnaire, etc.);

- Use grey highlighting or track changes so the Chair can easily see revisions.
- Upload a PDF version of the revised document(s), with a new version number, at the appropriate place in the application.
- Delete the old version of the document(s) from the application.

4) Summarize the Revisions for the Chair;

- Create a document that lists each reviewer comment (and question number), along with your response to the comment. For guidance, consult the Sample Summary of Revisions document (See Help/Templates in the top menu of MacREM, or click < [here](#) >).
- Use italics, or some other visible formatting, to distinguish your response from the reviewer comments.
- Any changes you make to the application that are in addition to responding to reviewer comments should be explained in the document as well.
- Upload the summary of revisions document to question 1.5 on the form.
- If you think it will be insufficient to use the summary document to address a concern you have with a specific reviewer comment, and that a discussion with the Chair may be necessary, please directly contact the reviewing Chair via email or phone.

5) Once everything is done you can sign the form to resubmit to the Chair.

Following the above steps will make it easier, and therefore faster, for the Chair to review the revisions. For a more comprehensive guide to responding to reviewer comments, see MacREM Quick Guide Respond to REB in Help/Templates or click < [here](#) >.

MREB Comments:

Review Form Comment

Title	Comment
1.3 Is this a post-doc, graduate or undergraduate student project?	If this is primarily Faculty research, then this response is fine as is. However, if the research is primarily for master's student work, then the response should be "yes" in order to add the student as the Student Principal Investigator on the next page and change the response to 2.10 to "no".
1.4 Please select the status of your application:	When re-submitting your protocol, be sure to select the first item: 'My revised application in response to ethics review comments from the MREB Chair'. You will then be prompted to upload your Summary of Revisions document in 1.5 - the subsequent section.
3.3 For which Level of Project(s) will the data be used? (Check all that may apply)	If this is primarily Faculty research then "Faculty" should also be checked.
8.2 Study Purpose/Research Question Description	Minor comment, this may be a typo, or an incomplete response; ie. is the question mark intentional?
10.6.7 Upload your email script(s) sent directly to participants.	- Minor comment, in both emails please add the MREB study number to the statement "This study has been reviewed and cleared by the McMaster Research Ethics Board [under study #8283]. - Be sure to add the student investigators name and email to this draft - A reviewer suggests adding a note about social risks to this document so that participants can make this consideration early on (refer to comment on 14.6) - Much like you have written in the oral consent script, please include a statement like "I located your name/email by visiting the website of {research software name}."
10.6.12 Upload your appreciation letter/certificate thank you card for participants.	Minor comment; This reviewer notices a couple of typo's ; Appendix title is missing the 'A' , and "...your personal confidentiality would be maintained," perhaps intend "will be..." or similar ?
14.6 Description and management of Social Risks	Refer to 3rd bullet point on 10.6.7. Some specialized OSS software may have very small development teams, sometimes only 1 developer making anonymity difficult or impossible. You have covered that possibility in this section, however a reviewer believes it would be worth mentioning it in the recruiting email as well.
15.2.2 Describe the administrative purpose(s) for which this information is required.	Please be aware of additional risk related to transfer of emails between password protected accounts, particularly if the accounts are not within one email system. Also be aware of potential cache or intermediate copies that may be created in email clients (including web browser based clients), or views/previews of attachments on user devices. Any incidental copies should be handled with the same level of security and privacy as the source data.
15.11.1 Describe how research data will be collected securely	Please be aware that deleting files or resources on a cloud service may leave a retrievable copy for some length of time (often 30 days). The retrieval should only be possible for users who originally had access. It might be worthwhile to investigate disabling this feature, or simply accommodating or maintaining awareness of the retrieval/undelete time inherent in the cloud platform.
16.6.2 Upload your oral / telephone consent script.	- This script notes that you are obtaining signed consent "The risks have been described in the letter of consent that has been signed". Please clarify in 16.1 - Please revise to reflect the social risks noted in section 14 - Please reflect that the data will be stored for 3 years
16.6.3 Upload your Letter of Information / consent - Participants.	Please include the following consent bullets before the consent questions: •I have read the information presented in the information letter about a study being conducted by [Insert researcher's name(s)], of McMaster University. •I have had the opportunity to ask questions about my involvement in this study and to receive additional details I requested. •I understand that if I agree to participate in this study, I may withdraw from the study at any time or up until [insert specific date – e.g., April 15, 2018] •I have been given a copy of this form. •I agree to participate in the study." Note that our standard consent statement and the ethics office email address have changed. This comment also applies to the consent script in 16.6.2. Please revise the MREB statement to align with the following: "This study has been reviewed by the McMaster Research Ethics Board and received ethics clearance under project #8215. If you have concerns or questions about your rights as a participant or about the way the study is conducted, please contact McMaster Research Ethics Office by phone: (905) 525-9140 ext. 23142 or e-mail: mreba@mcmaster.ca. "

Title	Comment
	The most current document templates and guides can be found on our website: https://research.mcmaster.ca/home/support-for-researchers/ethics/macrem/macrem-templates/

If you have any questions or concerns about the review comments, please contact the research ethics office at ethicsoffice@mcmaster.ca or the reviewing Chair.

Dr. Tara La Rose

Dr. Tara La Rose, MREB Chair

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